

Whither Mankind?

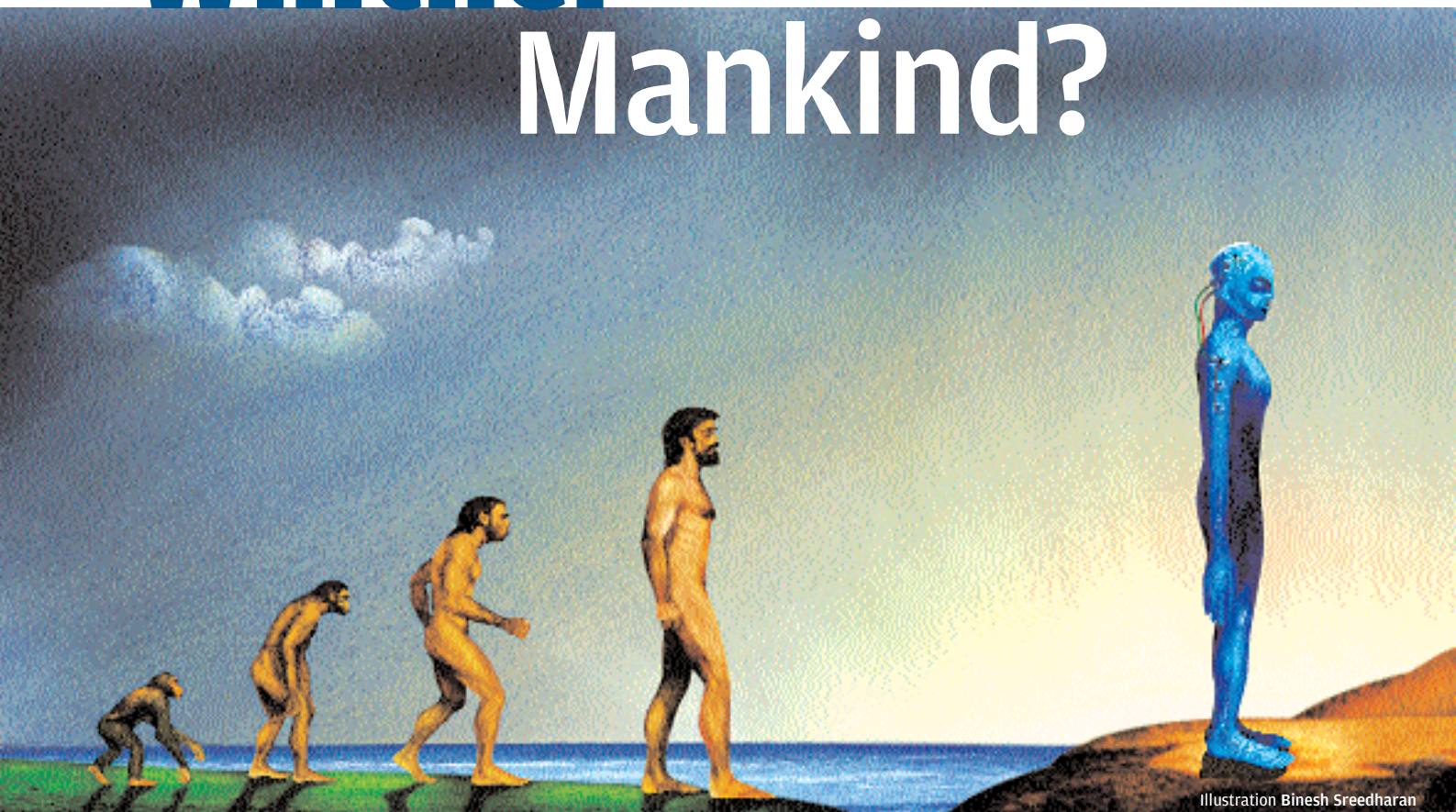


Illustration Binesh Sreedharan

The advancement of the physical form is possible using implants and various electro-mechanical devices

"The body is neither a very efficient nor very durable structure. It malfunctions often and fatigues quickly; its performance is determined by its age. It is susceptible to disease and is doomed to a certain and early death. Its survival parameters are very slim—it can survive only weeks without food, days without water and minutes without oxygen."

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Immortality! Mankind's greatest desire, and the driving force behind the medical sciences. Utter the word, and most of us start dreaming of all the things we could accomplish or the way our lives would alter if we could live forever; the thought is surreal. However, immortality, or at least a vastly enhanced and elongated lifespan, is not entirely fictitious or far-fetched any more. All mankind needs to do, is evolve.

We have seemingly hit a plateau on the ladder of evolution, and it's time we started climbing again. It's time we broke out of the shackles we were born into, not just in terms of lifespan, but also in terms of physical limitations. As the Extropy Insti-

tute (www.extropy.org) puts it, "Human beings achieved 'civilisation' thousands of years ago.

Yet, we have not shaken off the ancient tyrannies that haunt the human condition. We suffer physical and emotional sicknesses ending in decrepitude and death. The primitive parts of our brain spur us to envy, hate, despair, and kill. Our philosophies and religions attempt to express our highest values, yet, we use them to oppress and control. We use them to crush the world's complexity into a simplicity that we can clutch to like a security blanket for the human condition."

The Human Condition

Hundreds, perhaps thousands of things, define the human condition. We do not communicate efficiently enough—our speech is but glorified grunts compared to the immense possibilities of direct brain-to-brain communication. Our experiences are defined by hundreds of limiting factors such as distance, time, atmospheric conditions, and so on. The simple fact is that our minds are evolving, but our experiences are limited by the imperfect construction of these vessels called bodies that carry our advancing brains.

The logical progression would then have to be the advancement of the physical form. This is possible using implants and various electromechanical devices. To put it succinctly, mankind needs to physically evolve by turning Cyborg.